

FIELD FEATURE · ILLUMINATE RUNG

Thread Report

What SpecAssay pins to every pull request.

A passing Gate proves the thread holds — but a reviewer still has to read the diff, and a green check quietly borrows credibility for everything in it. So on every PR, SpecAssay posts one briefing: what moved on the Golden Thread, the touched story walked end to end, and the changes that sit *far from the thread*. The briefing **illuminates; it never blocks** — a broken Gate is refused by a separate check.

[See the real PR →](#)

A normal pull request

This walkthrough is a **real PR** on the bundled example app. A developer paid off some tracked debt — `AC-SYNC-02`, the disjoint-field merge — by adding the proof that was owed, and dropped in a small metrics module along the way.

Four files changed:

<code>tests/test_sync.py</code>	adds <code>test_AC_SYNC_02_...</code> — the proof	on the thread
<code>specs/sync/tasks.md</code>	closes the debt task <code>T005</code>	on the thread
<code>src/sync.py</code>	carries <code>@covers AC-SYNC-02</code>	on the thread
<code>src/metrics.py</code>	new — event counters, no mark	far from the thread

SpecAssay changes **nothing** about the PR itself — not its title, not its description, not its diff. It leaves the human's artifact alone and posts a comment beside it. What follows is that comment, verbatim, section by section.

The briefing it pins to it

1

 Thread Report

 Golden Thread intact

One line, one fact: does the thread hold. A passing Gate does not mean "everything is done" — it means nothing *unfinished* is *hidden* at acceptance-criterion altitude. No colour on the word — the dot carries it, so it reads the same in a comment and here. What *changed* lives below.

2

WHAT MOVED

 [AC-SYNC-02](#) — tracked-debt → **proven** ↑ · [test_sync.py](#) [sync.py](#)

The debt was paid. SpecAssay diffs the base manifest against the PR-head manifest. Here one acceptance criterion moved from owed to answered-for. The ID links to its line in the registry; the trailing files are the on-thread changes that *did* the moving — its proof and [@covers](#) — each a click to the exact diff. Minted, retired, and carrier-added rows show here too.

3

THE THREAD NOW – SYNC

 AC-SYNC-01	proven	
 AC-SYNC-02	proven	◀ changed

+2 untouched backlog rows not shown.

The touched story, walked top to bottom — as it stands *after* this PR, with the moved row flagged. Untouched *backlog* rows this PR never moved are hidden — the count is stated, never silently dropped — so the reviewer sees the live part of the thread, not the whole planning tree.

FAR FROM THE THREAD

1 changed file sits **far from the thread** — it changed, but nothing in it carries a mark tying it to an intent this PR moved:

`src/metrics.py`

This is the whole point. `metrics.py` changed, but nothing in it touches an intent this PR moved. SpecAssay surfaces it — as a *clickable* spotlight straight to the diff hunk — and stops there. A legitimate refactor and unwanted scope look identical from here, so the machine refuses to guess. It hands the reviewer a spotlight, not a verdict.

When the thread breaks

The green PR above is the happy path. But the report earns its keep loudest on the *unhappy* one. Here is [PR #2](#): a developer marks the debt task done and moves on — but never writes the proof it promised. `AC-SYNC-02` now has nothing standing behind it. The Gate refuses, and the report says so, in the same shape:



 Thread Report

 **Golden Thread broken**

WHAT MOVED

 [AC-SYNC-02](#) — tracked-debt → **GAP ↓**

The break is illuminated, not hidden. An acceptance criterion slid from owed-but-tracked to a *silent gap* — no proof, no open TODO excusing it. The report posts this briefing anyway, headed **broken**, so a reviewer reads *what* broke in thread terms, not just a red ✕.

Post the report, then block — two steps, never one. The comment always posts, even when the Gate refuses; a *separate* CI step then re-reads the verdict and fails the check. The briefing illuminates; the check refuses. The comment is never itself the block.

[See the broken PR #2 →](#)

Why a comment, and never a block

The report never fails the build. That's doctrine, not a limitation — three postures, in increasing intervention and decreasing frequency:

ILLUMINATE — ALWAYS ON

The briefing above. It surfaces what's decision-relevant and renders no verdict. "Far from the thread" lives here.

AFFIRM — OPT-IN

A team can set `offthread_ack: required` to turn the far-list into a one-click human tick before merge. That's a *person's* verdict, gated behind a lightweight config — never the machine's.

REFUSE — RARE, PROVABLE

The Gate blocks only on what it can prove is a defect: a silent acceptance-criterion gap, an invented ID, exact-set drift. Off-thread is not machine-decidable as a defect, so it never earns a refusal.

The machine may only refuse what it can prove is a defect. For the rest, it makes a human look.

And it stays a comment: SpecAssay posts beside your PR, it never edits it. The diff is the record; the Thread Report is the reading glass.

[See it live on PR #1 →](#)

SpecAssay hallmarks the work; Loupe reads the mark.

Thread Report is the illuminate rung — a briefing on every PR.

GitHub

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